The Great Law of Peace

Haudenosaunee (Iroquois) Confederacy · founded c. 1450 (pre-contact)

Source: "The Constitution of the Five Nations," oral tradition transcribed by Arthur C. Parker, New York State Museum Bulletin (1916)

Long before European contact, five nations — the Mohawk, Oneida, Onondaga, Cayuga, and Seneca (joined by the Tuscarora c. 1722) — united under a single Great Law of Peace to form the Haudenosaunee, or Iroquois, Confederacy. A council of chiefs (sachems) governed by consensus. The Confederacy demonstrates the political sophistication and lasting institutions of Indigenous North America centuries before Europeans arrived. Preserved orally for generations, the law was written down only much later.

Connect: How does the Great Law challenge the idea that complex, organized government "began" in North America with European colonization?

Key Passages

Planting the Tree of Peace

"I am Dekanawidah and with the Five Nations' Confederate Lords I plant the Tree of the Great Peace … Roots have spread out from the Tree … and the name of these roots is the Great White Roots of Peace. If any man or any nation shall obey the laws of the Great Peace … they may trace the roots to their source … and shall be welcomed to take shelter beneath the Tree."

The duty of the chiefs

"With endless patience [the Lords] shall carry out their duty, and their firmness shall be tempered with tenderness for their people. Neither anger nor fury shall find lodgement in their minds, and all their words and actions shall be marked by calm deliberation."

Self-control in leadership

"The thickness of your skin shall be seven spans — which is to say that you shall be proof against anger, offensive actions, and criticism."

HIPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	Before European contact (c. 1450), the Mohawk, Oneida, Onondaga, Cayuga, and Seneca ended generations of warfare by uniting under one law, forming the Haudenosaunee (Iroquois) Confederacy.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	The member nations and their chiefs (sachems), clan mothers, and people, who passed the law down orally; it was written down for outsiders only in the early 1900s (Parker, 1916).
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	From the perspective of the Haudenosaunee themselves, preserved through oral tradition; the English text is a later transcription and translation, so some wording reflects the recorders.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. SAQ practice (A·C·E): Identify ONE way the Great Law shows political complexity in pre-contact North America.

2. What qualities does the Great Law expect of its leaders, and why might those matter for a confederacy?

3. Why is a source preserved orally for generations both valuable and challenging for historians to use?